



LECTURE NOTES

(PAD 122)

ECOLOGY OF PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION

NOT FOR SALE

1.0 Appreciate the Concept of Ecology of Administration

The ecology of administration is an academic framework that explores how public administrative systems interact with and are influenced by their external environment. The term "ecology" is borrowed from biology, where it refers to the interrelationships between organisms and their surroundings. In public administration, this concept signifies that administrative systems cannot function in isolation but are deeply embedded in the socio-political, economic, cultural, and technological contexts of their respective societies.

Fred W. Riggs, a prominent scholar in comparative public administration, developed this concept further through his "Fused-Prismatic-Diffracted" model, which examined the characteristics of administrative systems in traditional, transitional, and modern societies. According to Riggs, a nation like Nigeria fits into the prismatic society, where both traditional and modern values coexist, often creating contradictions in administrative behavior.

Understanding the ecology of administration allows policymakers and administrators to design systems that reflect the local realities of the environment in which they operate. For example, while Western administrative models emphasize legal-rational authority and impersonality, these principles might not always be applicable in countries with strong tribal affiliations, patronage systems, or communal values. In Nigeria, the success or failure of administrative reforms is often tied to how well they align with environmental factors such as ethnic diversity, religious plurality, colonial legacy, and socio-economic conditions.

Thus, appreciating the ecology of administration means recognizing that effective governance is not one-size-fits-all. It requires tailoring administrative systems to suit the local environment for greater legitimacy, efficiency, and responsiveness.

1.1 Define Ecology of Administration

The ecology of administration is defined as the study of the interaction between an administrative system and the environment in which it operates. It entails analyzing how external factors such as political institutions, cultural norms, social values, economic structures, and technological advancements influence public administration.

Fred Riggs emphasized that administrative systems evolve in response to their environments. For instance, in traditional societies, administration may be fused with kinship and religion, whereas in modern societies, administrative functions are differentiated and specialized. Nigeria, as a transitional society, exhibits a mixture of both characteristics.

The ecological approach moves beyond the internal mechanics of public institutions to consider the broader context. It challenges administrators to understand how local customs, power dynamics, and historical experiences shape public expectations and administrative practices.

1.2 Explain the Various Components of the Environmental Factors as They Affect Administrative Practice in Nigeria

Administrative practice in Nigeria is shaped by several environmental factors, each exerting significant influence on how policies are made and implemented. These components include:

1. **Cultural Factors:** Nigeria is a multicultural nation with over 250 ethnic groups. Cultural diversity affects communication, leadership expectations, conflict resolution, and policy acceptance. In some regions, traditional authorities still wield significant influence, and any policy that disregards local customs may face resistance.
2. **Political Factors:** The political climate in Nigeria is characterized by frequent changes in leadership, party politics, and electoral tensions. Political instability often disrupts policy continuity. Furthermore, political patronage undermines meritocracy in civil service recruitment and promotion.
3. **Economic Factors:** Nigeria's economy is heavily reliant on oil revenues, making it vulnerable to global price fluctuations. Economic instability affects budgetary allocations, project execution, and civil servant salaries. High levels of poverty and unemployment increase demand for social services and put pressure on administrative agencies.
4. **Technological Factors:** Although Nigeria has made strides in digital governance, many areas still lack access to modern technologies. The digital divide affects the efficiency and transparency of administrative processes. E-governance initiatives are hindered by poor infrastructure, limited internet penetration, and inadequate ICT training.
5. **Legal and Institutional Factors:** Weak legal institutions and inconsistent law enforcement affect the credibility of public administration. Where laws are selectively applied, corruption thrives, and public trust in administrative institutions diminishes.

6. Historical Factors: Colonialism introduced centralized administrative systems that often ignored indigenous governance structures. The post-independence era inherited these systems without adapting them to local realities, creating a disconnect between administrators and the public.

2.0 Identify the Impacts of Social System on Public Administration

The social system encompasses the network of norms, values, institutions, and relationships that define a society. Public administration, as a subsystem of the larger society, is both shaped by and shapes this social system. In Nigeria, the social system has a profound impact on the operations, perceptions, and legitimacy of public institutions.

Public administration in Nigeria does not exist in a vacuum; it mirrors the socio-cultural realities of the society. For example, the extended family system and tribal affiliations influence public sector hiring, resource allocation, and loyalty patterns. The religious composition of society also affects policy decisions, especially on moral and social issues.

Social structures determine who participates in governance, whose interests are prioritized, and how policies are received. Administrators must understand and engage with these structures to enhance policy effectiveness and public trust.

2.1 Discuss the Impact of Social System on Public Administration

The Nigerian social system impacts public administration in the following ways:

-1. **Recruitment and Representation:** The Federal Character Principle is designed to ensure equitable representation of different ethnic groups in public service. While

it promotes inclusivity, it sometimes compromises meritocracy and fosters mediocrity.

2. Corruption and Nepotism: Social obligations to family, tribe, or religion often lead to favoritism in hiring, promotions, and contract awards. This erodes professionalism and reduces efficiency in public administration.

3. Civic Engagement and Accountability: Low levels of education and political awareness in some regions reduce civic engagement and weaken demands for accountability. Citizens may accept poor service delivery due to low expectations or fear of authority.

4. Gender Roles: Patriarchal norms limit the participation of women in administrative and political positions. This affects the gender sensitivity of policies and perpetuates inequality in public service delivery.

5. Informal Institutions: Traditional rulers, religious leaders, and local elites influence administrative decisions. Sometimes, informal authority structures have more legitimacy than formal government institutions.

2.2 Describe the Effect of Social System on Administration

The effects of the social system on administration in Nigeria are both enabling and constraining:

Positive Effects:

- Social cohesion in rural communities facilitates collective action and local development projects.

- Informal networks can complement formal structures in conflict resolution and community mobilization.

Negative Effects:

- Tribalism and favoritism compromise merit and lead to inefficiency.
- Resistance to change, especially from conservative social groups, hinders administrative innovation.
- Loyalty to ethnic or religious groups can override national interest, undermining policy implementation.

Administrators must navigate these dynamics skillfully to maintain legitimacy, ensure equity, and promote national integration.

3.0 Appreciate the Administrative Structures of the Pre-Colonial Administration in Nigeria

Prior to colonialism, Nigerian societies operated indigenous administrative systems tailored to their cultural and ecological contexts. These systems were effective in maintaining law, order, and economic productivity. Appreciating pre-colonial administration provides insights into governance models rooted in local realities and helps correct misconceptions that African societies were unorganized before colonization.

The three dominant systems were:

- Centralized systems (e.g., Sokoto Caliphate, Oyo Empire),
- Semi-centralized systems (e.g., Benin Kingdom),
- Decentralized or acephalous systems (e.g., Igbo communities).

Each had mechanisms for leadership selection, dispute resolution, public safety, and resource management. These indigenous structures continue to influence local governance today, especially through the role of traditional institutions.

3.1 Explain the Administrative Governance in Pre-Colonial Nigeria

Administrative governance in pre-colonial Nigeria was structured and functional. For example:

Hausa-Fulani (Northern Nigeria): Governance was based on Islamic principles.

The Emir served as both political and spiritual leader, supported by district heads (Hakimi) and religious scholars. The legal system was based on Sharia law.

Yoruba (Western Nigeria): Governance was monarchical. The Oba (king) had sacred authority but was subject to the advice of the Oyo Mesi (council of chiefs).

The Ogboni society also played a significant role in checking the power of the king.

Igbo (Eastern Nigeria): Governance was decentralized. Leadership was exercised by councils of elders, titled men, and age grades. Decisions were made collectively, and the society emphasized participatory democracy.

3.2 Describe the Administrative Structures of the Pre-Colonial Administration

Pre-colonial administrative structures were adapted to local realities and included:

- **Rulers:** Kings, emirs, or chiefs who provided leadership and symbolized unity.
- **Councils:** Bodies of elders or advisers who assisted in decision-making.
- **Judiciary:** Customary courts or religious authorities resolved disputes.
- **Military Units:** Responsible for defense and expansion.

- **Tax Collectors:** Ensured resource mobilization for the community.

These structures were not bureaucratic in the modern sense but were effective in mobilizing resources, maintaining order, and legitimizing authority.

3.3 Explain the Legislative, Executive, and Judicial Functions in Pre-Colonial Administration

Legislative Function: Laws were based on customs, religious tenets, and communal agreements. In centralized systems, laws were decreed by rulers; in decentralized ones, laws emerged from consensus.

Executive Function: Rulers, chiefs, and designated officials enforced laws, collected taxes, and organized labor for communal projects. They also coordinated defense and diplomacy.

Judicial Function: Disputes were settled using customary laws or religious principles. Punishments ranged from restitution to banishment. The focus was on restoration and harmony rather than retribution.

These functions illustrate that governance in pre-colonial Nigeria was sophisticated and contextually relevant, contrary to colonial narratives that dismissed indigenous institutions.